would hurt them."[70] This was for two reasons—first, China could exploit the resultant vacuum, and second, the US would further demote India in its strategic framework, leaving India without a key source of protection and assistance.

American assistance remained crucial for India, and thus Delhi had little desire to upset the US by emphasizing differences. When it came to the Vietnam War, Gandhi publicly noted that US and Indian differences had "narrowed."[71] The State Department indeed commented, "India no longer lectures us on the US role in Vietnam and has even indicated a desire to be helpful." Furthermore, even the Indian reaction to the US exploring the establishment of facilities on Diego Garcia "has been muted to date, despite their public stance against great power military activity in the Indian Ocean."[72] In fall 1969, Delhi also considered and then desisted from recognizing the Democratic Republic of Vietnam (DRV or North Vietnam)—in large part because of the potential adverse American reaction, at a time when India was questioning Soviet reliability and the US Congress had again been questioning aid to India.[73]

Indian policymakers also conveyed their support for the US relationship. When they met in Washington in July, Dinesh Singh, perceived to be pro-Soviet and mistrustful of the West,[74] hailed Nixon's comment that the US was looking to play a role in Asia "far beyond Vietnam." Singh welcomed US assistance for development, emphasizing the significant demonstration effect of democratic countries like India closing the gap between expectations and reality. Nixon agreed, noting, "If India did not make the grade, the lesson for the rest of the world would be disastrous." He indicated that it was "vital" to support—and not underfund—development programs.[75]

Delhi was concerned about declining American interest in India. While recognizing that there was a sense in the US that India was "too big to tackle," Gandhi publicly called for continued US help, saying India was making "steady progress."[76] In the lead-up to Nixon's visit to India in summer 1969—part of what was labeled his reassurance tour to Asia[77]—senior Indian officials prepared Gandhi to make the case for the importance of India. Haksar stressed to Gandhi the need to convince the US that communist influence in Asia could be limited "only by strengthening or stabilising forces in Asia, which, they must see, inevitably depends on the